

Get aggro on agri via specialty fertilisers

India's **farm sector**, heavily **reliant on** imported fertilisers, **is** again **bearing the brunt of** external **manipulations** - this time due to delay of shipments of **soluble fertilisers** under **China Entry-Exit Inspection and Quarantine (CIQ)** process. These 'designer' fertilisers are **essential** for fruit and vegetables. Of the 6 lakh tonnes of non- subsidised specialty fertilisers imported annually, about 80% is from China. Domestic production **accounts for** 10%, with the remaining sourced from other countries. During June-Dec crop cycle alone, India imports 1.5-1.6 lakh tonnes. China's low-grade economic **sanctions** shouldn't surprise India. Over the past four years, Beijing has **intermittently imposed** restrictions on fertiliser exports, **underscoring** risk of concentrated dependencies in a geopolitically **fractured** world.

Unlike bulk fertilisers like urea, diammonium phosphate (DAP) or muriate of potash (MoP), soluble fertilisers are high-value, low-volume products designed for **precision** farming. They allow nutrients to be delivered through **drip irrigation systems**, improving **yield**, reducing **runoff** and **preserving** soil health. As India shifts towards protected cultivation and high-value agriculture, **demand** for these **inputs** **is** expected to grow to around 1 mn tonnes by 2029. So, it can't afford to treat this delay as a **one-off**.



A starting point is reforming the outdated Fertiliser (Control) Order (FCO), which heavily **penalises** Indian manufacturers. They must **secure** multiple licences, **set up** state-wise warehouses and **comply with onerous** paperwork. Foreign suppliers enjoy a far smoother path to market entry. India must now take serious steps to **scale up** domestic production. This includes reviving **idle** fertiliser plants, supporting innovation in **nano-** and specialty **fertilisers**, and **strengthening PPPs**. **Diversifying** import sources **is** essential. But equally important is promoting balanced nutrient use, including organics and biofertilisers. Fertiliser security is **key** to food security. **The clock is ticking**.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[Practice exercise]

Vocabulary

1. **Aggro** (noun) – problems and difficulties.
2. **Specialty fertilizer** (noun) – Specialty fertilizers help to increase nutrient uptake because the ratio of nutrients can be adjusted and delivered based on the plant's nutrient requirements at a particular stage of growth.
3. **Reliant** (on) (adjective) – Dependent, trusting, needing, counting on, leaning on निर्भर
4. **Bear the brunt of** (phrase) – Face the worst, suffer most, take the impact, endure, withstand का खामियाजा सहन करना
5. **Manipulation** (noun) – Control, influence, exploitation, maneuvering, handling हेरफेर
6. **Soluble fertiliser** (noun) – a type of fertilizer that readily dissolves in water, allowing plants to quickly absorb the nutrients through their roots or leaves घुलनशील उर्वरक
7. **China's Entry-Exit Inspection and Quarantine** (noun) – responsible for the management of import and export commodities inspection area. चीन का प्रवेश-निकास निरीक्षण और संगरोध
8. **Essential** (adjective) – Necessary, crucial, vital, indispensable, fundamental आवश्यक
9. **Account for** (phrasal verb) – Constitute, represent, comprise, make up, contribute का हिस्सा होना
10. **Sanction** (noun) – Restriction, penalty, embargo, ban, punitive measure प्रतिबंध
11. **Intermittently** (adverb) – Sporadically, occasionally, irregularly, on and off, periodically रुक-रुक कर
12. **Impose** (verb) – Enforce, apply, levy, implement, mandate थोपना
13. **Underscore** (verb) – Emphasize, highlight, stress, reinforce, accentuate जोर देना
14. **Fractured** (adjective) – Broken, divided, fragmented, split, disjointed टूटा हुआ/बिखरा हुआ
15. **Unlike** (preposition) – Different from, dissimilar to, in contrast to, not like, opposed to के विपरीत
16. **Precision** (adjective) – Accurate, exact, meticulous, detailed, careful सटीक
17. **Drip irrigation system** (noun) – a method of watering plants where water is delivered directly to the plant's roots at a slow, controlled rate through a network of tubes, pipes, and emitters ड्रिप सिंचाई प्रणाली

18. **Yield** (noun) – Production, output, harvest, return, crop उपज
19. **Runoff** (noun) – Drainage, overflow, outflow, surplus water, water escape बहाव
20. **Preserve** (verb) – Protect, maintain, conserve, safeguard, keep सुरक्षित रखना
21. **Input** (noun) – a resource such as materials or labour that is involved in producing something and has a cost that affects profits
22. **One-off** (noun) – something that happens or is made or done only once एकबारगी घटना
23. **Penalise** (verb) – Punish, discipline, fine, penalize, sanction दंड देना
24. **Secure** (verb) – Obtain, acquire, get, procure, gain प्राप्त करना
25. **Set up** (phrasal verb) – Establish, create, organize, start, install स्थापित करना
26. **Comply** (with) (verb) – Follow, obey, adhere to, conform, meet पालन करना
27. **Onerous** (adjective) – Burdensome, heavy, taxing, arduous, demanding कठिन/कष्टदायक
28. **Scale up** (phrasal verb) – Expand, increase, grow, boost, amplify विस्तार करना
29. **Idle** (adjective) – Inactive, unused, stagnant, unproductive, dormant बेकार
30. **Nano fertiliser** (noun) – nutrients that are encapsulated or coated within nanomaterial in order to enable controlled release, and its subsequent slow diffusion into the soil. नैनो उर्वरक
31. **Strengthen** (verb) – Reinforce, bolster, enhance, fortify, support मजबूत करना
32. **PPPs** (noun) – Public-Private Partnerships, a long-term arrangement between a government and private sector institutions. सार्वजनिक-निजी भागीदारी
33. **The clock is ticking** (phrase) – Time is running out, deadline approaching, urgency increases, limited time left, hurry up समय निकलता जा रहा है

Summary of the Editorial

1. India's farm sector relies heavily on imported fertilisers, especially specialty soluble fertilisers essential for fruit and vegetable farming.
2. Recent delays in shipments from China, caused by China's Entry-Exit Inspection and Quarantine (CIQ) process, have disrupted supplies.
3. India imports about 6 lakh tonnes of non-subsidised specialty fertilisers annually, with 80% coming from China.
4. Domestic production of specialty fertilisers contributes only around 10% of India's needs.
5. Between June and December alone, India imports 1.5–1.6 lakh tonnes of these fertilisers.
6. China's restrictions on fertiliser exports highlight the geopolitical risks of depending on a single country for critical inputs.
7. Unlike bulk fertilisers such as urea, DAP, or MoP, soluble specialty fertilisers are high-value and low-volume, designed for precision agriculture.
8. These fertilisers enable nutrient delivery through drip irrigation, boosting yields, reducing nutrient runoff, and protecting soil health.
9. As India moves toward high-value agriculture and protected cultivation, demand for specialty fertilisers could rise to 1 million tonnes by 2029.
10. Treating the current delay as a temporary issue would be a mistake; it exposes deeper structural vulnerabilities.
11. The outdated Fertiliser (Control) Order (FCO) creates hurdles for Indian manufacturers through excessive licensing, paperwork, and warehousing requirements.
12. Foreign suppliers, ironically, face fewer barriers to entering India's fertiliser market compared to domestic producers.
13. India must urgently ramp up local production of specialty fertilisers by reviving idle plants and encouraging innovation in nano- and specialty fertilisers.
14. Strengthening public-private partnerships (PPPs) and diversifying import sources beyond China are crucial steps.
15. Promoting balanced nutrient use, including organics and biofertilisers, is equally important to ensure fertiliser security, which directly impacts India's food security — the clock is ticking.

now attract a lower 5% GST, as would unfried, uncooked snack pellets, fish-soluble paste and imitation zari yarn. It is not clear why the Council took six years after the GST rate tweaks these rates, imported for cancer diseases, for instance, envisaged earlier as with intended higher tax levies. Dissuading the use of larger personal vehicles is an obvious necessity for a country where traffic congestion is intense and widespread. The impact of some decisions on individual sectors will depend on the fine print, but the Council, which may meet less frequently in the upcoming poll season, has taken its eye off the promised overhaul of GST rates. The new success was named to steer the ministerial group on rate restructuring, previously helmed by erstwhile Karnataka Chief Minister, B.S. Bommai.

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